A Plan to Swap Land Stirs Debate on Cumberland Island

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Wild horses, **feral** hogs, and deer roam free on Cumberland Island, a Georgia island off the Atlantic coast, 18 miles long. Its **salt marshes**, forests, and beach can only be reached by ferry. The National Park Service has looked after the island since 1972, including about 9,800 acres of wild land that Congress said should stay in its natural state forever.

But the island is not only wild land. It also has old mission **ruins**, **plantation ruins**, and grand homes built long ago by Thomas Carnegie and his wife Lucy. Their family still lives or spends holidays on land there, and the park service has suggested a land swap that would allow new homes to be built.

Under the plan, park land on the west side would go to two branches of the Carnegie family for up to eight new homes. Park leader Melissa Trenchik says this would help protect nature and historic places on the Atlantic side, where building could then be banned.

Critics say the homes would be far too big, while the family calls the island **sacred**.

Word Treasure

feral -- Feral means a wild animal that once lived with people but now lives free.

salt marshes -- A salt marsh is a wet, grassy place near the sea where salty water covers the land.

ruins -- Ruins are the broken parts of old buildings that are left standing.

plantation -- A plantation is a large farm where crops were grown long ago.

sacred -- Sacred means very special and holy to a person or a group.

Background you need

A national park is a special place that is protected so its wild animals, plants, and old buildings can stay safe.

Some islands can only be reached by boat, which helps keep their wild land quiet and hard to reach.

When people disagree about building on protected land, they sometimes swap one piece of land for another to try to protect the most special parts.

Break it down

WHO: The National Park Service, the Carnegie family, park leader Melissa Trenchik, and critics of the plan

WHAT: The park service has suggested a land swap that would give park land to the Carnegie family for new homes

WHERE: Cumberland Island, a Georgia island off the Atlantic coast

WHY: The park service says the swap would help protect nature and historic places on the Atlantic side, while critics say the new homes would be far too big

Why it matters

It matters because the choices grown-ups make about wild places decide whether animals keep a safe home and children can still visit nature in the future.

Test what you remember

1. What animals roam free on Cumberland Island?

(A) Deer and rabbits
(B) Wild horses, feral hogs, and deer
(C) Bears, wolves, and foxes
(D) Wild horses and sheep

2. How can people reach the island?

(A) Only by ferry
(B) By car over a bridge
(C) By train
(D) By walking from the beach

3. What has the National Park Service suggested?

(A) Selling the whole island
(B) A land swap that would allow new homes to be built
(C) Closing the salt marshes
(D) Banning all visitors from the island

4. Under the plan, what would the Carnegie family get?

(A) All the land on the Atlantic side
(B) The old mission ruins
(C) A new ferry to the island
(D) Park land on the west side for up to eight new homes

5. What does park leader Melissa Trenchik say the plan would do?

(A) Let homes be built everywhere on the island
(B) Move the wild horses away
(C) End all building on the island
(D) Help protect nature and historic places on the Atlantic side

6. What do critics say about the homes?

(A) They would be too small
(B) They would be far too big
(C) They would be built of wood
(D) They would be hidden in the forest

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Park leader Melissa Trenchik: She says the land swap would help protect nature and historic places on the Atlantic side, where building could then be banned.
2. Critics: They say the homes would be far too big.
3. The Carnegie family: They call the island sacred.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):